

Presentation Opening Hooks

Topic: The Resume Empathy Gap

Audience: College Students

1. The Question Hook

The Script:

"Quick show of hands — how many of you have spent more than three hours formatting a single resume? Fonts, margins, bullet alignment, the works?

Now — how many of you have spent three hours explaining what your actual work *means* to someone who's never met you?

...Right. That's the problem I want to talk about today."

Delivery Note: Actually pause for the hands to go up — don't rush past it. Let the silence after the second question sit for a beat before you deliver the line. The contrast between the two hand-counts *is* the hook.

2. The Surprising Statement Hook

The Script:

"A recruiter who spent a decade hiring for Google, TikTok, Uber, and The New York Times says the biggest resume mistake she sees isn't a typo.

[Pause]

It isn't bad formatting either.

It's this: candidates write their resume for the one person who already understands it completely —

[Pause]

themselves."

Delivery Note: Deliver the recruiter's credentials fast and confidently to establish authority. Slow way down on "themselves" — let it land as the twist, since the audience expects the mistake to be something technical.

3. The Storytelling Hook

The Script:

"Picture a recruiter at her desk. She's got 200 resumes in the queue and six seconds — six — to decide whether yours is worth a second look.

She lands on your proudest bullet point: 'Managed the transition to the Delta Protocol.'

She has no idea what the Delta Protocol is. She has no idea if it mattered. So she moves on. Your best work — the thing you were proudest of — just got you rejected."

Delivery Note: Speak the first line briskly to build urgency, then slow down deliberately on "six seconds" and hold eye contact with the room. Let "rejected" land flat and quiet — no upward inflection.

4. The Big Promise Hook

The Script:

"By the end of this talk, you'll know exactly why a perfectly formatted, achievement-packed resume can still get rejected in under ten seconds — and you'll walk away with a simple three-part formula that fixes it, one you can apply to your resume tonight."

Delivery Note: Say this with total confidence — no hedging language like "hopefully" or "I think." This is a promise, not a suggestion, so let your posture and pace stay steady and direct.

5. The Visual Action Hook

The Script:

(Hold up a printed resume, front-facing to the audience, and say nothing for 3 full seconds.)

"This resume has perfect formatting. Zero typos. Impressive numbers.

(Circle a bullet point on it with a red marker, live.)

And it just got rejected. Not because of what's wrong with it — because of what's invisible in it."

Delivery Note: The silence before you speak is doing the work — resist the urge to fill it. Marking the paper live (rather than showing a pre-marked slide) makes the moment feel spontaneous and keeps eyes on you, not the screen.

Notes for Kareem

All five hooks are built around the core diagnosis in your source material: the "curse of knowledge" — candidates write with context only they have, and recruiters can't fill in the gaps in six seconds. Pick the hook that matches your natural delivery style; the Storytelling and Visual Action hooks tend to land best for a college audience since they're concrete and hard to tune out.